

One Match, An Entire Region

Lesson 38 — The Arab Spring begins: Tunisia and Egypt

What you will know and be able to do

1

Explain the specific incident that triggered Tunisia's revolution, and the grievances behind it

2

Trace how protest spread from Tunisia to Egypt, and why it spread so quickly

3

Describe how eighteen days of protest ended Mubarak's thirty-year rule

4

Evaluate the role of social media against other, longer-term underlying causes

The region's most recent transformation

Everything covered so far in this regional study — from Nasser to Al-Qaeda — unfolded before this course's most recent chapter. This final block covers the uprisings that reshaped the region beginning in December 2010, and the sharply divergent paths they produced.

Sidi Bouzid, 17 December 2010

Mohamed Bouazizi, a 26-year-old Tunisian street vendor supporting his family by selling fruit without the required permit, had his cart and produce confiscated by local officials after a confrontation with a municipal inspector. That afternoon, he set himself on fire in protest — dying of his injuries on 4 January 2011.

A single story, a shared condition

Bouazizi's death crystallised grievances many Tunisians already shared under Zine el-Abidine Ben Ali's twenty-three-year authoritarian rule: high unemployment, rising food prices, entrenched corruption, and no meaningful political freedom. His individual tragedy became a symbol precisely because his situation was so widely, unremarkably familiar.

The Jasmine Revolution

Protests spread rapidly from Sidi Bouzid to Tunis and beyond, uniting the unemployed, students, lawyers, trade unionists, and human rights activists in a broad coalition that transcended any single political faction. Facing this scale of unrest, Ben Ali fled to Saudi Arabia on 14 January 2011 — less than a month after Bouazizi's self-immolation, and barely two weeks after his death.

Inspiration travels fast

Ben Ali's rapid fall convinced activists elsewhere that similarly entrenched regimes might also be vulnerable. Protests spread within weeks to Algeria, Jordan, Yemen, and — most consequentially for this course's purposes — Egypt, where young organisers used social media to coordinate demonstrations directly inspired by Tunisia's example.

25 January 2011: the Day of Rage

Protests erupted across Egypt on 25 January, rapidly concentrating in Cairo's Tahrir Square, where tens of thousands of demonstrators gathered daily demanding Hosni Mubarak's resignation — the same Mubarak whose government had negotiated Camp David's aftermath and ruled Egypt for three uninterrupted decades.

Tahrir Square, by the numbers

18 days

From the first mass protests to Mubarak's resignation

30 years

Length of Mubarak's rule, ended on 11 February 2011

**Tens of
thousands**

Protesters gathering daily in Tahrir Square at the movement's peak

Mubarak's fall made him the second Arab Spring ruler toppled within a single month, after Ben Ali.

Unrest across the region

Within months, sustained demonstrations had also broken out in Bahrain, Libya, Syria, Yemen, Morocco, Iraq, Lebanon, Jordan, Kuwait, Oman, and Sudan, with smaller protests reaching Djibouti, Mauritania, and even Saudi Arabia itself — an unprecedented, region-wide wave of popular mobilisation against long-entrenched authoritarian rule.

How much did social media actually matter?

Mobile phone footage and social media undeniably helped protests spread faster and more visibly than earlier uprisings could have. Academic researchers modelling the wave's spread, however, note that the precise mechanism by which these platforms translated into political outcomes remains genuinely unclear — a caution against treating technology alone as a sufficient explanation.

Rentier stability, tested and confirmed

Recall Lesson 28's rentier state theory: oil-poor Tunisia and Egypt, lacking the resources to buy the kind of political quiescence Gulf monarchies could afford, proved far more vulnerable to this wave of unrest than Saudi Arabia, whose 2011 cash payments helped ensure protests there never gained comparable traction.

Not every uprising followed the same script

Tunisia and Egypt saw relatively swift, if incomplete, political transitions. Even at this early stage, however, the uprisings beginning in Libya and Syria were already taking a very different, far more violent course — the subject of our next lesson.

Tunisia and Egypt, side by side

TUNISIA

- Sparked by a single, specific individual's death
- Ben Ali fled the country entirely within weeks
- A smaller population and more homogeneous political landscape
- Went on to draft a new, internationally praised constitution by 2014

EGYPT

- Inspired by Tunisia's example rather than a single domestic trigger
- Mubarak resigned but remained in Egypt; military took interim control
- A far larger population and more complex, competing political factions
- Descended into further upheaval, including a 2013 military coup

Similar triggers, different institutional starting points

Tunisia's smaller scale and stronger civil-society institutions, including its trade union movement, gave its transition more to build on than Egypt's, where the military itself remained the most powerful, cohesive institution throughout — a difference that mattered enormously once the initial euphoria of each revolution's early days had passed.

Two data points are not a pattern

It is tempting to already generalise about “why some Arab Spring uprisings succeeded and others failed” based on Tunisia and Egypt alone. Our next lesson adds Libya and Syria specifically because a genuinely comparative judgement needs more than two cases — the same caution about false equivalence and premature generalisation this course has applied throughout its comparative work.

A full essay attempt

'Long-standing economic grievances, rather than the specific example of Bouazizi's death or the use of social media, best explain why the Arab Spring spread so rapidly across the region.' To what extent do you agree?

- State your position and evaluative criterion clearly
- Use specific evidence from both Tunisia and Egypt
- Address the counter-argument that specific triggering events and communication tools mattered independently

Key terms from today

Self-immolation

Setting oneself on fire as an act of protest; Bouazizi's specific method.

Day of Rage

25 January 2011, the start of Egypt's mass protests.

Jasmine Revolution

The media name for Tunisia's 2010–11 uprising.

Domino effect

One uprising's success encouraging similar movements elsewhere.

What to remember

Mohamed Bouazizi's December 2010 self-immolation crystallised widely shared Tunisian grievances into a revolution that toppled Ben Ali within a month, directly inspiring Egypt's own eighteen-day uprising that ended Mubarak's thirty-year rule. Social media accelerated these movements' spread, but underlying economic and political conditions, and each state's own resource base, shaped how far and how successfully unrest actually travelled.

Lesson 39 — Libya and Syria: divergent paths

Next lesson: why the same regional wave produced international intervention in Libya and a devastating, prolonged civil war in Syria — two outcomes as different as any in this entire course.